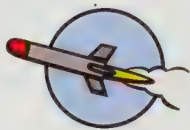


new job title, less work, less people (or no people), and will eventually have a hard time finding anything of any real value to do all day. Not long after this, that same employee will be out on the street. In fact, if you're at work and have enough time to read this article, you may very well be in the firing line.



8. Has your office, cubicle, or space been downsized?

Remember poor old Milton in *Office Space* being moved from one small space to another, until he eventually sat in the dark, in the basement, dealing with pest problems? Well, this is not so far from the truth. When employees are in the firing line, it's a lot easier to move them around and downsize their environment without worrying about their morale. If you are reading this in your new 6 x 6-foot cubicle with no lights on a 1999 PC with a 200MB hard drive, you're not exactly a valued employee anymore.

9. Do people whisper more, or does the conversation change as you approach?

If you're marked for termination, you'll be the last one to know about it. And being the grown-up responsible people that

they are, your coworkers will be quite happy to whisper about your impending doom in a dark corner of the coffee room. Until you show up, when suddenly the conversation will change abruptly to something really original . . . like the weather.

10. Did you recently receive a pay freeze or cut?

There are a few reasons this could happen; none of them are good. Either the company is in trouble and they need to cut costs, or you're in trouble and they don't want to pay you. If it's the first one, you may not necessarily be in immediate danger, but no one wants to work for a company that's going down the tubes (read *Who Moved My Cheese?* for more on that one). If it's the latter, well, your boss is basically telling you that you're about as welcome as a fart in an astronaut suit. Begin the job hunt immediately.

11. Have you seen a job posting for your company that matches your job description?

Human Resources can be crafty. They don't want to fire you without having someone waiting in the wings to immediately fill your shoes. That's why